

Surya · Nehan · Jashith · Meenakshi

Who we met

01

Saree wholesale

Shivajinagar

Four wholesale shops

02

Flower stall

St Mary's Basilica

40 years, same spot

03

Meat corner

Cockburn Road

10 to 15 years

04

Sweet and chaat stall

Shivajinagar market

Several years

The visit at a glance

When

A weekday, morning into afternoon, just before Dasara

Where

Cockburn Road, Russell Market lanes, St Mary's Basilica and the square

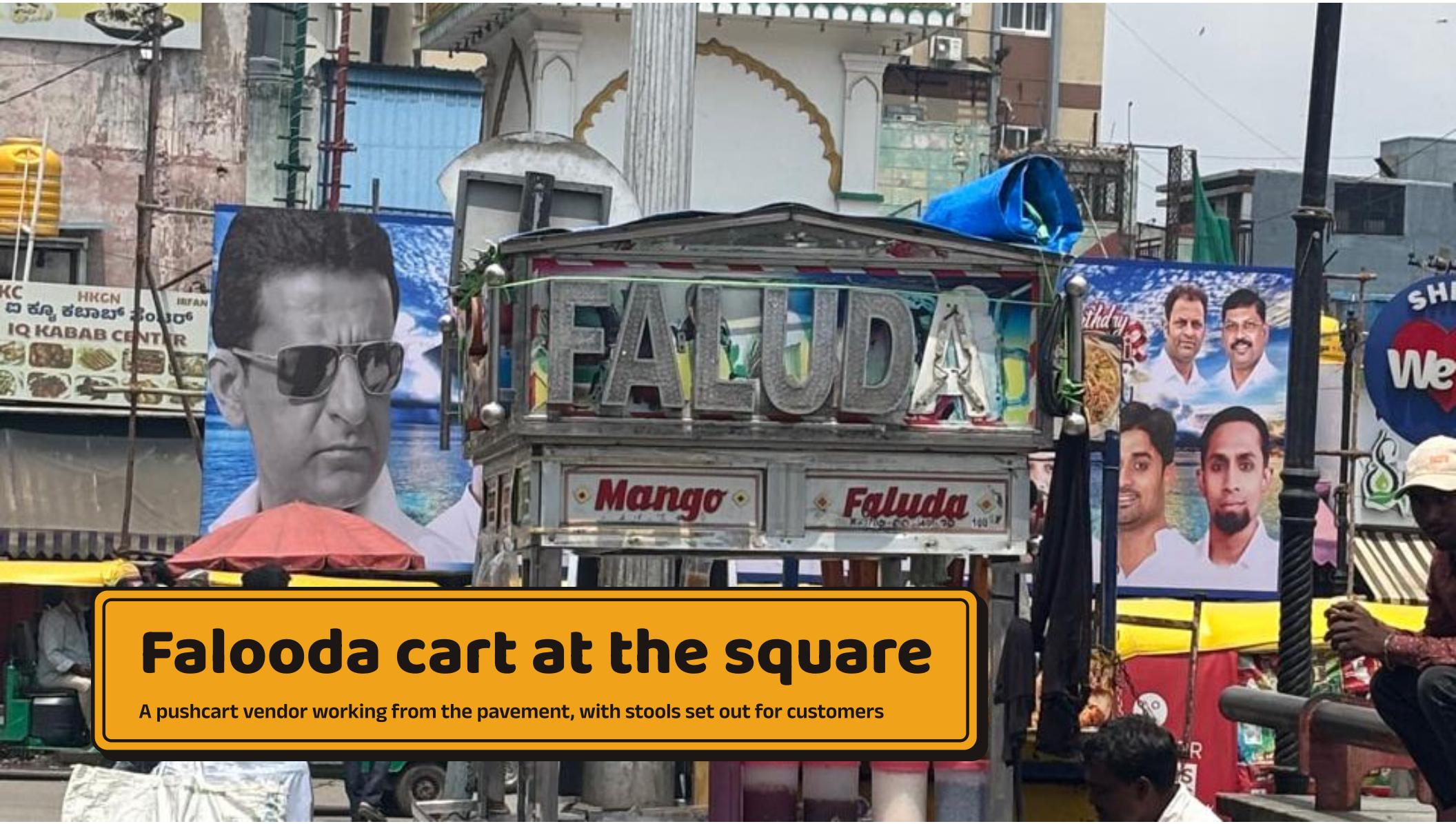
Why

How small vendors work with suppliers, customers, space and city services

Part 1

Photos

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Falooda cart at the square

A pushcart vendor working from the pavement, with stools set out for customers

Behind the counter



New Taj Durbar, open since 1980. Takeaway and the shawarma counter face the street; seating is on the floors above.



A restaurant kitchen nearby: charcoal cooking under a hood, open steel racks, one aisle.

Part 2 · Interview 01

Saree wholesale

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Saree wholesale

Shivajinagar **01**

We spoke with the owner of a wholesale saree shop. He has four shops in Shivajinagar, all wholesale. He said the market has slowed, as more buyers now go to Chickpet, where the collection is bigger and prices are lower. Alongside sarees and dress material, the shops stitch wedding suits and lehengas.

- Two hours after opening, there had been no customers.
- Weekends, Dasara, Diwali and weddings bring most of the business.
- Opening a shop here, he said, depends on talking to neighbouring shopkeepers and local elders.

Saree wholesale

Interview 01 · Shivajinagar **01**

We asked	They said
Why is the market not like before?	More people go to Chickpet now. The collection is bigger and it is cheaper.
Where does your stock come from?	From outside. When stock runs out, more comes in.
When do customers come?	Saturday, Sunday and festivals. Dasara and Diwali are coming, so it should pick up.
Is it hard to open a shop here?	No trouble. You just have to talk to the other shopkeepers and the people in charge.
Do people ask for discounts?	Yes, but we are wholesale, with four shops, so not much.

हम लोग का दिमाग Chikpet जाता नहीं है।

We don’t think of going to Chickpet.

01 **Saree wholesaler**

Shivajinagar · Interview 01

Arif K. 01

Age	Not asked
Business	Saree wholesale, bridal tailoring
Set-up	Four wholesale shops
Peak	Weekends, festivals, weddings
Languages	Hindi
Tools	Not asked

Context

Arif K. is a Hindi-speaking saree wholesaler who owns four wholesale shops in Shivajinagar, selling sarees and dress material and stitching wedding outfits in-house. His sales are uneven: weekends, Dasara, Diwali and the wedding season bring most of the year's business, while weekdays can pass with few customers. Many buyers now go to Chickpet for a wider range and lower prices. A long slow spell would not only leave stock unsold; it could tie up the money needed to restock before the next festival.

Goals

G1. Keep wedding and festival buyers coming to Shivajinagar instead of Chickpet.

G2. Restock in time for the season without holding money in slow weeks.

G3. Give customers fabric, stitching and bridal wear in one visit.

Motivations

Keep four shops going through slow weeks.

Offer good quality even when Chickpet is cheaper.

Keep good relations with neighbouring shops and local elders.

Supply everything from festival to wedding.

Pain points

P1. Chickpet is cheaper, so buyers go there.

P2. Weekdays bring long hours with few sales.

P3. Most income arrives in a few festival and wedding weeks.

Says

- Fewer customers come now; more go to Chickpet.
- The market stays quiet for hours after opening.
- Anything needed for a wedding can be found here.

Thinks

- Quality here is good; Chickpet is just cheaper.
- A good festival season could balance out the slow months.
- If stock sits too long, money for the next order is stuck.



Arif K.

Saree wholesale

Empathy map

Does

- Restocks from outside suppliers when shelves run low.
- Takes measurements and delivers stitched outfits in two to three days.
- Keeps in touch with neighbouring shopkeepers and local elders.

Feels

- Waiting through a quiet morning feels discouraging.
- Losing buyers to another market feels hard to control.
- The festival season brings hope, not certainty.

Part 2 · Interview 02

Flower stall

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Flower stall

St Mary's Basilica **02**

We spoke with a flower seller who has worked from the same spot outside St Mary's Basilica for 40 years. He buys his flowers at KR Market, opens at 6 am and closes at 10 pm.

- All his stock stays inside the stall overnight.
- Flowers last about two days and usually sell within that time.
- Asked what had changed, he mentioned only the new buildings and the church being repainted.

Flower stall

Interview 02 · St Mary's Basilica **02**

We asked	They said
How long have you been here?	40 years.
When do you open and close?	Six in the morning. Ten at night.
Where do you buy flowers?	City market, KR Market. I go at 2 in the afternoon and am back by 3.
Where do you keep stock at night?	Here. All of it stays in the stall.
How long do flowers stay fresh?	Two days. It all sells by then.
What has changed around here?	Not much. New buildings. The church was repainted.

Anthony D. 02

Age	Not asked
Business	Flowers
Here for	40 years, same spot
Hours	6 am to 10 pm
Languages	Hindi
Tools	Not asked

Context

Anthony D. is a Hindi-speaking flower seller who has worked from the same spot outside St Mary's Basilica for 40 years. Each afternoon he goes to KR Market at about 2 pm and is back by 3, and the stall stays open from 6 am to 10 pm. All his stock stays in the stall overnight, and flowers last about two days. A wrong estimate would not only waste the flowers; it would cut into the money for the next purchase.

Goals

G1. Buy only as many flowers as will sell within two days.

G2. Keep his spot outside the Basilica.

G3. Manage the daily market trip and long hours.

Motivations

Keep the stall he has run for 40 years.

Sell to people on their way into the church.

Keep the routine he knows.

Pain points

P1. Flowers lose value within two days, while the cost is paid upfront.

P2. All stock stays in the stall overnight.

P3. A 16-hour day leaves little time for rest.

Says

- Forty years in the same place.
- The flowers last about two days.
- Not much has changed here, only the buildings.

Thinks

- If the flowers don't sell by tomorrow, the money is gone.
- Two days is all the flowers have.
- The same customers have come for years.

AD

Anthony D.

Flower stall

Empathy map

Does

- Goes to KR Market at 2 pm, back by 3.
- Keeps the full stock inside the stall overnight.
- Sells from the same spot outside the Basilica.

Feels

- A 16-hour day is long.
- Wilting stock on the second day brings worry.
- Being part of the place for 40 years brings quiet pride.

Part 2 · Interview 03

Meat corner

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Meat corner

Cockburn Road **03**



We spoke with the owner of a chicken and mutton stall on Cockburn Road. Most of his customers are regulars from nearby homes, and he remembers many of their usual cuts and quantities. Evenings from 5 to 8 pm and Sundays are his busiest times.

- He buys stock from experience and calls another supplier when one runs short.
- Regulars rarely question small differences in weight; he sometimes adds a little extra.
- When asked what would help, he named reliable stock, waste collection, a good fridge and help in busy hours.

Meat corner

Interview 03 · Cockburn Road **03**

We asked	They said
When is the shop busiest?	Evenings, 5 to 8 pm, and Sundays when families buy for lunch.
Do customers bargain?	Rarely. They know the rate. They care about the cut and the weight.
How do you decide how much to stock?	Experience. I know weekdays, weekends and Sundays. If one supplier is short, I call another.
How do you keep track of orders?	Phone calls, WhatsApp, UPI, a notebook, and memory.
What would make work easier?	Reliable stock, easier waste collection, a good fridge, and help in busy hours.

“

Keeping a customer happy matters more than arguing over a few grams.

03

Meat stall owner

Cockburn Road · Interview 03

Riyaz Q. 03

Age	40 to 45
Business	Chicken and mutton
Here for	10 to 15 years
Opens	7 to 7:30 am
Languages	Not asked
Tools	Phone, WhatsApp, UPI, notebook

Context

Riyaz Q. is a meat seller who has run a chicken and mutton stall on Cockburn Road for 10 to 15 years. Most customers are regulars from nearby homes, and he remembers many of their usual cuts and quantities. Evenings and Sundays are busiest, and he buys stock from past weeks' experience because demand is not known in advance. A power cut or a missing helper would not only slow service; it could put stock, hygiene and customer trust at risk on the same day.

Goals

G1. Buy enough stock for the day without being left with extra.

G2. Serve the evening rush quickly while giving each customer the right cut.

G3. Keep the shop clean even when customers are waiting.

Motivations

Keep regular customers coming back for years.

Be trusted on weight, freshness and cut.

Not depend on a single supplier.

Have reliable refrigeration and waste pickup.

Pain points

P1. Stock is bought before the day's demand is known.

P2. When the helper is absent, every task falls on him.

P3. Power cuts and late waste pickup affect freshness and hygiene.

Says

- Regular customers don't argue over a few grams.
- Evenings and Sundays are the busiest.
- A clean shop and good behaviour bring people back.

Thinks

- Too little stock loses sales; too much may go bad.
- A UPI payment may not have arrived yet.
- Stock will not hold long if the power goes.

RQ

Riyaz Q.

Meat corner

Empathy map

Does

- Calls a second supplier when the first runs short.
- Moves between cutting, weighing, packing and payment.
- Cleans the block and knives between customers.

Feels

- Wet hands make handling the phone uncomfortable.
- A busy evening without help feels overwhelming.
- Being trusted by regulars feels like a responsibility.

Part 2 · Interview 04

Sweet and chaat stall

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Sweet and chaat stall

Shivajinagar market **04**



We spoke with the owner of a small North Indian sweet and chaat counter. The room holds burners, gas cylinders and large kadais, with the customer counter at the front. Sweets are made in batches; chaat is put together when ordered.

- Dahi and chutneys go into several items, so one running out affects many.
- Customers can easily go to another stall if the wait is long.
- Anything new, he said, would have to work while he is cooking.

Sweet and chaat stall

Interview 04 · Shivajinagar market **04**

We asked	They said
Who are your customers?	Residents, shop workers, people working nearby, people passing through.
What is hardest about the work?	Not bargaining. Keeping up with the flow while keeping food and counter clean.
How do you know how much to make?	Experience and the day of the week. Too much is bad because freshness matters.
How do people pay?	UPI mostly, and cash. In a rush, payment is one more job.
Would an app or software help?	Only if it works while I'm cooking. Typing things in would slow me down.

Mahesh S. 04

Age	35 to 45
Business	North Indian sweets and chaat
Here for	Several years
Peak	Evenings, weekends
Languages	Not asked
Tools	Phone, UPI, cash

Context

Mahesh S. is a sweet and chaat seller who has run a small takeaway counter in Shivajinagar for several years. He works in a narrow room shared with gas burners, cylinders and large kadais. Sweets are made in batches before evening; chaat is put together to order. Customers stay a few minutes and can easily choose another stall. If dahi or chutney runs out in the rush, it would not only stop one item; it could stop several and send the queue elsewhere.

Goals

G1. Serve the evening queue quickly without losing taste or quality.

G2. Prepare enough for the day without leftover food.

G3. Keep the counter and utensils clean during service.

Motivations

Keep regulars returning for their usual order.

Be known for consistent taste.

Use only tools that work while he is cooking.

Pain points

P1. One ingredient running out affects several dishes.

P2. There is no room for extra stock or packaging.

P3. Several burners in a small room make evenings hot and tiring.

Says

- Customers leave if the wait is too long.
- Regulars order without needing to ask.
- Anything new has to work while cooking.

Thinks

- Dahi and chutney need to last until the rush ends.
- Preparing too much means food may not stay fresh.
- There is nowhere to keep more stock.

MS

Mahesh S.

Sweet and chaat stall

Empathy map

Does

- Prepares chutneys and sweets before the evening rush.
- Cooks, assembles, packs and takes payment in turn.
- Wipes the counter whenever the queue allows.

Feels

- Heat from the burners builds through the evening.
- A growing queue brings pressure to work faster.
- Regulars returning brings reassurance.

Recordings

Saree wholesale

01

4:14 · Hindi

Listen for

Why buyers now go to Chickpet, and how festivals carry the year.

Flower stall

02

2:12 · Hindi, with street noise

Listen for

His daily route to KR Market and the two-day life of his stock.

Part 3

All four together

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Salim A.

All

Age	45
Business	Small family-run shop or stall
Here for	10 to 40 years
Peak	Evenings, weekends, festivals
Languages	Dakhni, Urdu, Tamil, Kannada, Hindi
Tools	Phone, WhatsApp, UPI, cash, notebook

Context

Salim A., 45, brings together the four vendors we met: a saree wholesaler, a flower seller, a meat seller and a sweet and chaat seller. He runs a family stall where he is owner, buyer, worker and cashier. Stock is bought before demand is known, based on years of experience and regulars he remembers. His income follows weekends, festivals and the evening rush. A disruption on a busy day would not only cost that day's sales; it could waste stock and weaken the trust of his regulars.

Goals

G1. Buy or prepare just enough for each day, without shortage or waste.

G2. Serve busy hours quickly without dropping quality or cleanliness.

G3. Keep regulars returning while nearby markets and stalls compete.

Motivations

Keep the family business running.

Be trusted by regulars on quality and fairness.

Stay independent and in control of his work.

Use only tools that fit around the work.

Pain points

P1. Stock is paid for upfront, while sales depend on festivals, weather and footfall.

P2. In the rush, one or two people handle every task at once.

P3. Power cuts and late waste pickup affect stock and hygiene.

Says

- Most customers are regulars who know us.
- Weekends and festivals bring the business.
- Anything new has to work while we are busy.

Thinks

- Too much stock may spoil; too little loses sales.
- A good festival season could make up for slow weeks.
- Customers can easily go elsewhere.

SA

Salim A.

All four vendors

Empathy map

Does

- Buys stock by experience, not written records.
- Serves, packs, takes payment and cleans in turn.
- Remembers regular customers and their usual orders.

Feels

- Long days leave the body tired by evening.
- Busy hours without help feel overwhelming.
- Regulars returning brings quiet reassurance.

Part 4

Five senses

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Shivajinagar through five senses

Sight	Signboards in Kannada, English and Urdu on one shopfront	A green-and-white minaret above film and party hoardings	Meat hung at the shop door; red menu boards in the sweet stall
Sound	Azaan from nearby masjids; bells from St Mary's	A cleaver on the wooden block; the hiss of gas burners	Auto horns and conversation in Dakhni, Tamil and Kannada
Smell	Jasmine and marigold at the Basilica gate	Charcoal smoke and ghee from kitchens	Raw meat, wet floors and warm sugar syrup
Taste	Gulab jamun, khova jalebi and rabdi	Mango falooda from a cart in the square	Kebabs, Irani chai and bun maska; haleem in Ramzan
Touch	Wet, slippery paving outside the meat stalls	Heat from open fires in narrow kitchens	Crowded pavements; gas hoses underfoot

What we observed

1

Decisions rest on experience

Stock, preparation and supplier choices are estimated from past weeks and known customers, with little written down.

2

One or two people carry the rush

Cooking, cutting, packing, payment and cleaning fall to the same hands. One absent helper changes the whole day.

3

Outside services shape the day

Suppliers, power, gas, water and waste pickup sit outside the vendor's control, yet each affects stock, hygiene and income.



Surya · Nehan · Jashith · Meenakshi